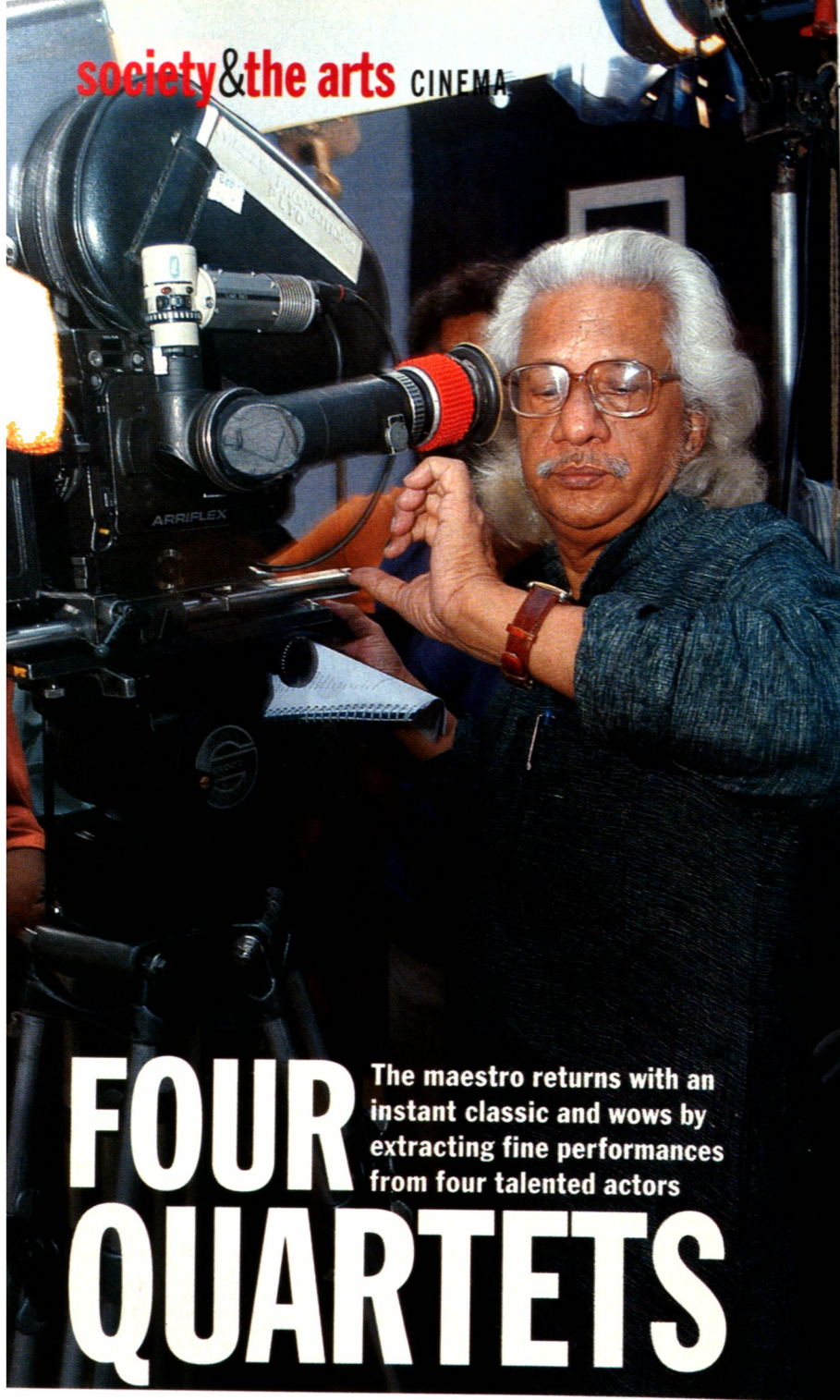




FOUR QUARTETS

The maestro returns with an instant classic and wows by extracting fine performances from four talented actors

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

I am increasingly keen on women these days. May be I am getting old," says celebrated filmmaker Adoor Gopalakrishnan, 66, with a wink, about his latest creation, *Naalu Pennungal* (Four Women), his first anthology film comprising four stories. The film—the tenth in a 35-year-long career—is based on short stories by late Jnanpith-award-winning writer Thakazhi Sivasankara Pillai and focuses on four young women,

played by prominent Malayalam movie actors Padmapriya, Geetu Mohandas and Manju Pillai, as well as art cinema's staple Nandita Das. Set in two decades between the '40s and '60s, Adoor is so inspired that he has already started working on his next film (most unusual for the leisurely-paced director), also based

GENIUS AT WORK: Adoor Gopalakrishnan on the sets of *Four Women*

on a Thakazhi anthology and also on women. "My mother was my greatest companion when I was young. Later too, women have been in a majority in my three-member family which consists of me, my wife and our only daughter," he says, before people start getting ideas.

Borne out of a project entrusted to him by Doordarshan in 2004 (to make a 10-episode serial), Adoor and his associates chipped in Rs 40 lakh to complete the Rs 1 crore, 105-minute film shot in the backwaters of Alappuzha, whose placid calm is occasionally disturbed by a slow moving boat which appears like a recurring motif in the film. All the women in the film are separated by time, space, class or social milieu. Yet they have surprisingly similar stories to tell. Stories, which tell how a woman's identity and life's journey is so crippling defined by standards and values set by an oppressive and patriarchal society.

The first story, *The Prostitute*, talks about a young sex worker (Padmapriya) discovering how impossible it is to lead a 'normal' life even after she gives up her profession and gets married. The law of the land simply does not recognise the legitimacy of the 'claimed' marriage of a street walker who has no known father, a proper address or even the evidence of formal wedlock. "Adoor is one of the last of the great masters of Indian cinema starting from Ritwik Ghatak and Satyajit Ray. So I did not want to miss a chance to work with him. I requested him to take me as an assistant director if there was no role for me," says Padmapriya, who has emerged a favourite with serious filmmakers in the South and was in the news recently for being slapped by Tamil director Saami. She recalls how the shooting was held on the streets of Alappuzha at night. "As a sex worker I slept on the verandahs of closed shops, with insects crawling all around me," she says, adding that the

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